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BSF Initiates Technical Study as Plan to Fence Challenging Sundarbans Terrain Gathers Pace

BSF initiates technical study as plan to fence challenging Sundarbans terrain gathers pace

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

In a first, the Union Home Ministry is set to fence about 90 kilometres of the Sundarbans along the India-Bangladesh border in West Bengal, a challenging terrain characterised by mangrove forests, tidal swamps, embankments, and numerous creeks.

The Border Security Force (BSF), which is deployed along the Bangladesh border, has initiated a feasibility and technical study to erect the fence along the land border with Bangladesh, a senior government official told *The Hindu*. At present, there are no barriers on the ground and the BSF has de-



Ground work: BSF Director-General Praveen Kumar interacting with people in the Sundarbans. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ployed Floating Border Outposts, or FBOPs, in the riverine areas to secure the border. Plans are afoot to augment marine patrolling, the official said.

Praveen Kumar, Direc-

tor-General, BSF, had visited the Sundarbans from July 11 to 14 and reviewed the progress of the fencing work. "No fencing work has ever been done in the Sundarbans till now. The

locals have been counselled that fencing is a requirement and that it is vital for national security. The joint inspection by the BSF and Department of Irrigation will start soon," said the official.

Protected area

As part of a public outreach, the BSF D-G met with local people and government officials in the area, a BSF statement said.

Almost 71 km of the border is contiguous with the Sundarbans Wildlife Sanctuary where no construction work is allowed as it is a protected area, the official said. "The three-day security review led by the D-G focused on time-bound completion of fence-relat-

ed work. The need for more searchlights and surveillance cameras to aid marine domination was discussed," said the official.

Another official said that people were concerned about their land being acquired for construction of the fence. "Several mid-scale hotels and lodges which operate in the area also raised concern. They have been assured that the government will compensate and rehabilitate them," said the official.

"Though the Sundarbans is not a preferred route for infiltrators, it is used for trans-border crimes. After August 2024, additional security measures were taken up here," said the official.

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- **The Plan**

- The Union Home Ministry is set to fence about 90 km of the Sundarbans along the India-Bangladesh border in West Bengal terrain of mangrove forests, tidal swamps, embankments and numerous creeks

- **Current Status**

- The BSF has initiated a feasibility and technical study to erect the fence; at present there are no barriers on the ground, and Floating Border Outposts (FBOPs) secure riverine areas
- This boundary has been determined under the **Radcliffe Award** which divided the erstwhile province of Bengal into two parts.

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Boundary States :

West Bengal, Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura, Mizoram

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Sundarbans

The Sundarbans hosts the **largest mangrove forests in the world**, lying on the delta of the Ganges, Brahmaputra and Meghna rivers on the Bay of Bengal.

40% of Sundarban lies in India and the rest in Bangladesh.

At about 4,096 km, it is **India's longest land border**, passing through **West Bengal, Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura and Mizoram**; most of it is already fenced except riverine/marshy stretches like the Sundarbans



Spanning across India and Bangladesh, Sundarbans is amongst the world's largest contiguous blocks of mangrove forest. Less than 40 percent of Sundarbans is located in India and the rest is in Bangladesh. On the Indian side, forest boundaries have changed very little since 1943.

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Basics

- **What Is the BSF?**

- India's primary border guarding force for the India-Pakistan and India-Bangladesh borders, functioning under the Union Ministry of Home Affairs

- **Legal Protections**

- Construction restrictions in protected wildlife areas stem from the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972, and forest conservation laws, creating tension with border infrastructure needs

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The Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) refers to seven security forces in India under the authority of Ministry of Home Affairs. Each of the seven has its own cadre of officers, but they are headed by officers of the **Indian Police Service**.

- Assam Rifles (AR) : (Dual Control : Operation Control under the Army and Administrative Control under MHA)
 - The Assam Rifles came into being in 1835, as a militia called the 'Cachar Levy', to primarily protect British Tea estates and their settlements against tribal raids.
 - Conduct counter-insurgency operations in the north-east and other areas where deemed necessary, under the control of the army.
 - During peace and 'proxy war', ensure security of the Indo-China and Indo-Myanmar borders.
 - During war, rear area security in the TBA

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- **Border Security Force (BSF)**
 - BSF is a Border Guarding Force of India. **Established on December 1, 1965**, it is a **paramilitary force charged with guarding India's land borders with Pakistan and Bangladesh**
- **Central Industrial Security Force (CISF)**
 - **Established: 1969** with 3 battalions to provide integrated security to Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs).
 - With economic liberalisation, **CISF evolved into a premier multi-skilled security force, protecting critical infrastructure beyond PSUs.**
 - CISF (Amendment) Act, 2009: Allowed deployment to **private and cooperative establishments** on a user-charge (fee) basis.
 - Also authorised **CISF to protect Indian missions abroad and participate in UN Peacekeeping Operations.**
 - Currently secures **Parliament, airports, seaports, metros, nuclear and space installations**, and other critical infrastructure.

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- **Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF)**
 - The Central Reserve Police Force came into existence as **Crown Representative's Police** on 27th July 1939. It became the Central Reserve Police Force on enactment of the CRPF Act on 28th December 1949.
 - The mission of the Central Reserve Police Force is to **enable the government to maintain Rule of Law**, Public Order and Internal Security effectively and efficiently, to Preserve National Integrity and Promote Social Harmony and Development by upholding the supremacy of the Constitution.
 - **Duties include Crowd Control, Riot Control, Control of LWE**
- **Indo Tibetan Border Police (ITBP)**
 - ITBP was raised on 24 Oct, 1962. Presently, ITBP is deployed on border guarding duties from **Karakoram Pass in Ladakh to Jachep La in Arunachal Pradesh** covering 3488 km of Indo-China Border
 - Apart from this, **the Force also has important roles in many internal security duties and operations against the Left Wing Extremism in the state of Chhattisgarh.**
- **Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB)**
 - The Sashastra Seema Bal, previously known as the Special Service Bureau, was established on 15 March 1963 after the **Sino–Indian Conflict of 1962.**
 - It was created with the objective of guarding India's international borders **with Nepal and Bhutan.**

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- **National Security Guard (NSG)**

- National Security Guard has been given the **role to handle all facets of terrorism** in any part of the country as MHA's Nodal National Counter Terror Force.
- The NSG was modelled on the pattern of the **SAS of the UK and GSG-9 of Germany**.
- It is a task-oriented Force and has two complementary elements in the form of the
 - **Special Action Group (SAG)** comprising Army personnel and the
 - **Special Ranger Groups (SRG)**, comprising personnel drawn from the Central Armed Police Forces / State Police Forces.

Kudankulam Nuclear Plant Data Leak Sparks 'Absolute Commotion'

Kudankulam nuclear plant data leak sparks 'absolute commotion'

P. Sudhakar
TIRUNELVELI

The leak of highly sensitive files of Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant (KKNPP), reportedly accessed by a ransomware group from a contractor's server, has triggered "absolute commotion" in the plant, KKNPP sources said on Wednesday.

After commissioning two 1,000 Mwe VVER reactors, KKNPP is building four more such units with Russian collaboration.

Sources said the top brass of the upcoming nuclear park is "completely clueless" about the development that poses a security threat as it may let an adversary map the support system and identify vulnerabilities.

According to Reuters, more than 19,000 files dating between 2016 and mid-2025, and linked to KKNPP's engineering blueprints on control, cooling and ventilation systems,



The reported data leak comes amid construction of four VVER reactors at the plant. FILE PHOTO

list of vendors and suppliers, etc. had been accessed by World Leaks.

Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited said the information claimed to be available in public domain pertains to "conventional balance of plant common service facilities" and does not relate to any nuclear safety or nuclear security-related systems.

The leak originated from a server hosted by third party provider Yotta. The plant's contractor, Anil Ambani's Reliance Group, has admitted that a "partial breach" had hap-

pened and the government had been informed.

"Suspicious activity on Yotta's server was noted on May 29 last and it was reported in June-end. Investigations by Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited, the project proponent, and Computer Emergency Response Team are on," the sources said.

Reliance Group's Reliance Infrastructure bagged the contract in 2018 to build infrastructure for reactors 3 and 4, both under construction.

When the KKNPP encountered a similar incident in 2019, wherein a North Korean malware infection on its administrative network exposed the plant's vulnerability, NPCIL had dismissed it saying that their "unbreachable standalone network" was intact and no data could be accessed by any dark web.

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Kudankulam plant data leak sparks 'commotion'

Neither KKNPP's site director Ashok Bhatiya, nor V.P. Sunil, Station Director (1 and 2), could be reached for their comments on this sensitive issue.

The senior manager of human resources and public relations Kannan, who would usually be in touch with the media for occasional press statements, also did not pick up repeated calls.

Kudankulam Nuclear Plant Data Leak Sparks 'Absolute Commotion'

Concept

- **The Leak**

- Highly sensitive files of the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant (KKNPP), reportedly accessed by a ransomware group from a contractor's server, triggered "absolute commotion" at the plant

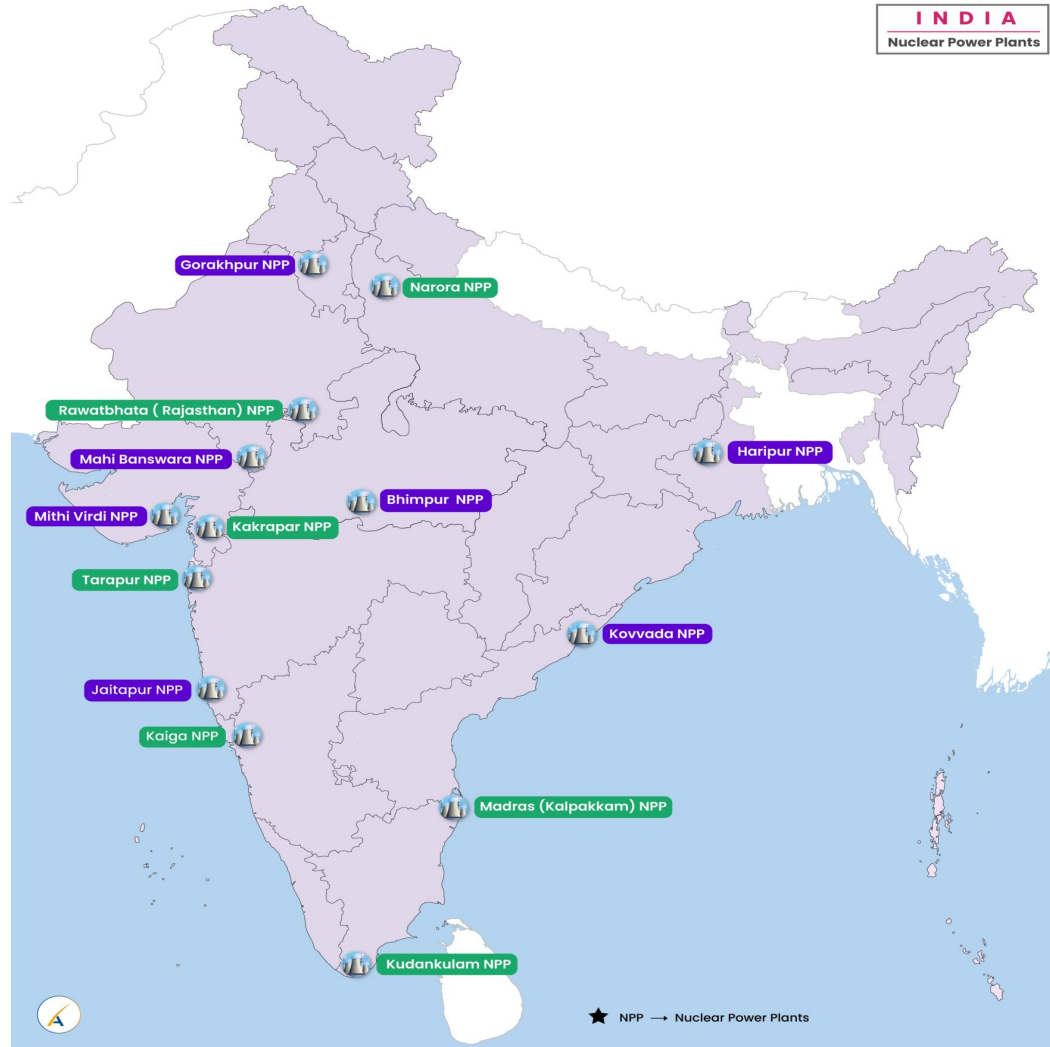
- **Scale of Exposure**

- Over 19,000 files dating between 2016 and mid-2025, linked to engineering blueprints on control, cooling and ventilation systems and vendor/supplier lists, were reportedly accessed by the group "World Leaks"

- **Origin of the Breach**

- The leak originated from a server hosted by third-party provider Yotta; the plant's contractor, Anil Ambani's Reliance Group, admitted a "partial breach" had occurred

Kudankulam Nuclear Plant Data Leak Sparks 'Absolute Commotion'



KALPAKKAM: Located 80 km south of Chennai on the Coromandel Coast

KUDANKULAM: Located in the Tirunelveli district of TN Under construction with the Russian assistance

KAIGA: Nuclear power station located in the Uttar Kannada district in Karnataka

TARAPUR: First nuclear reactor of India

KAKRAPARA: Located near Surat on the bank of the Tapi in Gujarat

RAWATBHATA: Located on the bank of the Chambal River about 65 km from Kota, just 3 km from the Rana Pratap Sagar

NARORA: Located in the Bulandshahr district of Uttar Pradesh on the bank of the Ganga

The Crisis at the Heart of Non-Proliferation

The crisis at the heart of non-proliferation

The present impasse over Iran's nuclear future lays bare the enduring hypocrisy at the heart of the global non-proliferation order. As talks in Doha stumble through disputes over frozen assets and verification mechanisms, Tehran is being pressed to accept full dismantlement of its enriched uranium stockpile in exchange for economic compensation for decades of sanctions, even as President Masoud Pezeshkian insists Iran will not relinquish its sovereign right to enrich uranium. The demand is unambiguous. Yet the five recognised weapons powers, and Israel, undeclared but widely known to possess the bomb, face no comparable ultimatum to disarm.

The current confrontation raises an unavoidable question: on what grounds should Iran relinquish a capability that nine nuclear states retain for themselves? The claim that Iran is uniquely dangerous, unstable, or aggressive is a conclusion in search of evidence, and cloaked in language by states whose own commitment to international law is selective at best.

Unequal rules

The Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT) institutionalised a hierarchy rather than dismantling it. It divided the world into nuclear "haves" and "have-nots," and enjoined the latter to restraint while the former continue to modernise their nuclear arsenals.

Against this backdrop, the treatment of Iran is not an anomaly. India and Pakistan, both outside the NPT, possess substantial nuclear arsenals and are welcomed as strategic partners by the very powers that patrol the non-proliferation order. Israel, whose nuclear programme is an open secret, has never submitted to inspection and is never named in the discourse of proliferation risk. Iran, by contrast, pursued enrichment within a legal



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The Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons institutionalised a hierarchy rather than dismantling it

framework, submitted to the most intrusive inspection regime in the history of arms control under the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), and was "rewarded" with unilateral American withdrawal, the reimposition of sanctions, and the renewed threat of military destruction. Iran complied and got punished anyway.

There is a deeper historical contradiction that the current discourse labours to suppress. The global nuclear order is, in a fundamental sense, anchored in an act of unparalleled destruction of Hiroshima and Nagasaki in August 1945. These remain the only instances in history of nuclear weapons being deployed in conflict. They established the catastrophic potential of such arms as well as the precedent that their use could be justified, and absorbed into the language of strategic necessity by the state that employed them. The U.S. survived this act morally, emerging successfully as the designated guardian of nuclear order.

This precedent complicates every subsequent moral claim. A state that has demonstrated the willingness to use nuclear weapons against civilian populations occupies a singular position when it seeks to regulate the ambitions of others. The authority it claims is derived from the fact of prior use, and from the geopolitical dominance that use helped to consolidate. Albert Einstein warned with characteristic precision that humanity must choose between abolishing war and facing annihilation. That choice stands only deferred, and most effectively by those with the largest arsenals.

The unravelling of the JCPOA remains one of the most instructive episodes in recent diplomatic history, precisely because it was so revealing. Negotiated painstakingly under the Barack Obama administration, the agreement represented a genuinely achieved instance of multilateral diplomacy. Its

abandonment by the Donald Trump administration in 2018 sent a message that resonated far beyond Tehran. For any state observing this trajectory, the conclusion inescapably underscores that future arms agreements with the U.S. carry no guarantee of American compliance. It must be kept in mind that if the Iran nuclear crisis deepens further, the JCPOA's destruction will stand as its proximate cause.

An enduring paradox

The question, in the end, is not whether Iran should or should not enrich uranium. It is whether the framework within which that question is posed is coherent, consistent, or just. By any honest reckoning, it is none of these things. Until that framework is confronted directly, and not obscured by the language of non-proliferation, the contradictions at the heart of the nuclear age will continue to compound. The answer to that question has been available since 1955, when Einstein and Bertrand Russell unambiguously asserted that nuclear weapons must be abolished altogether, by all states, without exception, or the logic of deterrence will produce the catastrophe it claims to prevent. Seven decades later, that conclusion remains as sound as ever.

We stand at a crossroads in a world that has grown accustomed to the gun on the table, until the day it goes off. Selective enforcement of non-proliferation, punishing Iran for compliance while rewarding others for defiance, and the indefinite deferral of the NPT's disarmament obligation do not constitute a rules-based order. They constitute a system that has chosen, knowingly, to tolerate the most destructive weapons in history rather than eliminate them. That choice carries a cost. The only question is whether we confront it through policy or through catastrophe.

The Crisis at the Heart of Non-Proliferation

- **What Is the NPT?**

- The Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (1968) divides the world into recognised nuclear weapon states (US, Russia, UK, France, China) and non-nuclear weapon states committing not to acquire nuclear weapons

- **India, Pakistan, Israel and the NPT**

- India, Pakistan and Israel are nuclear-capable states outside the NPT framework; India has consistently refused to sign, calling the treaty discriminatory

- **What Was the JCPOA?**

- A 2015 agreement between **Iran and world powers (P5+1(Germany))** placing strict limits and inspections on Iran's nuclear programme in exchange for sanctions relief; the US withdrew unilaterally in 2018

One Nation, One Election Will Not Fix What Is Broken

One Nation, One Election will not fix what is broken



VIJAY KELKAR
AND AJIT RANADE

INDIA'S PARLIAMENT is set to take up the Constitution (One Hundred and Twenty-Ninth Amendment) Bill to synchronise Lok Sabha and all state assembly elections, inserting a new Article 82A and amending Articles 83 and 172. The Bill requires a two-thirds majority in both Houses and ratification by half the states. After a High-Level Committee (HLC) chaired by former President Ram Nath Kovind, the government has committed to this push. The scale of the constitutional intervention demands rigorous scrutiny of the claimed benefits.

The HLC report rests on four pillars: Cost savings, relief from "policy paralysis" caused by the Model Code of Conduct, reduced burden on government manpower, and an economic growth dividend. Its economic anchor is a striking claim: Research by Prachi Mishra, N K Singh and colleagues finds that real GDP growth is approximately 1.5 percentage points higher following simultaneous election cycles. That single finding must be examined carefully.

The paper compares the simultaneous election era (1952–1967, partially until the mid-1980s) with the subsequent asynchronous period. But before reaching for the econometrics, consider the plain historical record. The era produced what economists call the "Hindu rate of growth": Around 3.5 per cent annually, decades of the licence raj, import substitution, and a closed economy. India's genuine high-growth era came entirely under asynchronous elections: The 8 to 9 per cent annual growth of 2003–2011 was achieved with staggered state polls running through every single year. If simultaneous elections drive growth, this history is very difficult to explain. The macro confounders — trade liberalisation, the IT boom, global capital flows, financial deepening, and the 1991 reforms — are too large to control away. More consequentially, the paper's own results show the growth effect operating partly through higher fiscal deficits and greater



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

government spending. Structural improvement, or a political business cycle merely compressed in time? A constitutional overhaul cannot rest on correlations that India's own history contradicts.

On costs, the argument collapses once you ask a simple question: Who is actually spending? The government's election expenditure is not even 0.1 per cent of its own budget, as ECI accounts confirm. The "excessive" spending is by candidates and parties. But the telling detail is this: Per audited accounts submitted to the ECI, the average official expenditure by candidates is 50 per cent of the permissible ceiling. Candidates are, on paper, underspending, not overspending. The implication is inescapable: The real money is not in any account. It is black money, unaccounted and untraceable, which the Centre for Media Studies estimates at over Rs 1,00,000 crore for the 2024 Lok Sabha election alone. No electoral calendar reform can touch this. The same political economy of cash, patronage and opacity prevails whether elections happen every year or once in five years. ONOE does not reduce election spending; it merely concentrates it.

On the Model Code of Conduct: The MCC restricts government announcements for roughly 45 to 60 days per election. Because India holds state elections in a rolling fashion, NITI Aayog estimates

some part of the country is under the MCC for about four months every year. Under ONOE, that rolling freeze becomes a single national freeze every five years, simultaneously halting developmental announcements across every state. The disruption is not eliminated; it is nationally concentrated and potentially more distorting. Calling this "policy paralysis" mistakes democratic restraint for administrative dysfunction.

The deeper objections are constitutional. The Supreme Court in *Kesavananda Bharati* has held that parliamentary democracy and free and fair elections are part of the Constitution's basic structure, a threshold even amendments cannot cross. Three specific tensions arise. First, parliamentary government rests on collective responsibility: The executive holds office only so long as it commands legislative confidence. Under ONOE, a government losing its majority would either continue without a legitimate mandate or trigger President's Rule — neither is acceptable. The HLC's proposed "constructive no-confidence motion", requiring any no-confidence vote to be paired with a simultaneous confidence vote for an alternative, is borrowed from Germany and distorts India's parliamentary tradition. As Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy researchers point out, it would incentivise minority governments to cling to office despite lacking popular support.

These require targeted reform: Mandatory disclosure of all donations, enforceable expenditure limits, disbarment of criminally tainted candidates, and a genuinely autonomous Election Commission

Second, reaching the first synchronised cycle requires extending or curtailing multiple state assembly terms. Articles 83 and 172 deliberately use the words "no longer" — a phrase the Constituent Assembly inserted to bar extensions beyond five years. Extending terms without fresh mandate breaches the voters' contract; curtailing them denies voters the period they voted for. Either way, the electorate's will is overridden.

Third, simultaneous elections structurally disadvantage regional parties, and the republic's federal character. Research shows a consistent "wave effect" when national and state elections coincide. Voters tend to choose the same party at both levels, giving large national parties a decisive advantage. Regional concerns such as agrarian distress in Vidarbha, coastal livelihoods in Kerala, or flood management in Assam, find parliamentary voice through regional formations. Bundling elections risks submerging these voices under national campaigns.

The ONOE framework also ignores elections to India's constitutionally protected third tier of government. The 73rd and 74th Amendments placed panchayat and urban local body elections under State Election Commissions, not the ECI, guaranteeing their autonomy. These are not minor contests. Mumbai, Pune and Bengaluru have budgets larger than many Indian states, and their elections are high-stakes political battles. Folding them into ONOE would violate the spirit of these amendments; keeping them separate undermines ONOE's own rationale. Substantial expenditure, security deployment, and governance disruption would continue through every panchayat and municipal cycle, leaving the claimed savings largely illusory.

What makes this particularly dispiriting is that the genuine pathologies of elections go untouched: Unlimited party spending, cash distribution to voters, criminalisation of politics, and misuse of state machinery. These require targeted reform: Mandatory disclosure of all donations, enforceable expenditure limits, disbarment of criminally tainted candidates, and a genuinely autonomous ECI. All these reforms are achievable without touching the Constitution's federal and parliamentary foundations.

The ONOE Bill reorganises the democratic calendar. It does not fix what is broken.

The writers are respectively, vice president and senior fellow, Pune International Centre

One Nation, One Election: Claims vs Objections

Claimed Benefits

- Cost savings;
- Relief from "policy paralysis" due to Model Code of Conduct;
- Reduced administrative burden;
- A claimed GDP growth dividend

Key Objections

- India's real high-growth era (2003-11) occurred under staggered elections;
- Government poll spending is under 0.1% of its budget;
- Disadvantages regional parties;

Green Energy Push, 7.5-GW Capacity Target: Gujarat's Data Centre Policy

Green energy push, 7.5-GW capacity target: Gujarat's data centre policy

Ritu Sharma
Ahmedabad, July 15

THE GUJARAT government last week announced a data centre policy for 2026-29, targeting investments of Rs 6 lakh crore and the creation of 7.5 gigawatts (GW) of capacity, which it says would be the highest in the country.

The policy lays out a wide range of incentives for investors, including duty and tax exemptions, relief in Floor Space Index (FSI), uninterrupted water and power supply and relaxations in building norms.

The Viksit Gujarat Data Center Policy (2026-29) follows Reliance Industries Ltd's announcement last month of a partnership with Meta to lease its first AI-enabled data centre in India, at Jamnagar in Gujarat.

Telangana was the first state in the country to announce a data centre policy in 2016, followed by Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Odisha, Maharashtra, Haryana and Andhra Pradesh.

Stress on green energy

Gujarat has claimed that its policy is among the most ambitious state-level frameworks for

DHOLERA CALLING

- The state government is looking to attract data centres to the Dholera region, 100 km south-west of Ahmedabad.

- To do this, the government has offered a capital subsidy of 2.5% on eligible fixed capital investment. This includes core technical and infra expenses but excludes the cost of land, land development and chips.

This comes amid a larger push for green energy in the industry. Google has announced plans to build an AI data centre campus in Andhra Pradesh powered entirely by clean energy. The Adani Group has announced a 5 GW data centre platform across India through its AdaniConneX joint venture, which will be powered by the Adani Green Energy park at Khavda in Kutch district. P Bhattacharya, Secretary of Gujarat's Department of Science and Technology (DST), told *The Indian Express*: "Gujarat is the first state to announce the largest capacity (hyperscale) data center as well as the first to have a dedicated policy in the country specifically designed for green AI data centres. More importantly, other states are working on a case-to-case basis and not under a dedicated policy like Gujarat."

Financial incentives

The Gujarat government has offered to exempt stamp duty and registration fee for leasing or buying land. It has also offered 100% reimbursement of electricity duty for 20 years and a subsidy at the rate of Re 1 per unit of power consumed by a data centre entity for 20 years, both starting from the date of commencement of commercial operations. The policy provides full reimbursement of eligible expenses on plant and machinery, building infrastructure and services for up to 20 years. It offers financial assistance for desalination plants to meet the sector's high water requirements.

Green Energy Push, 7.5-GW Capacity Target: Gujarat's Data Centre Policy

- **What Is a Data Centre?**

- A facility housing computing infrastructure that powers cloud computing, AI model training and digital services increasingly power- and water-intensive as AI adoption grows

- **Why States Compete for Data Centres**

- They bring large capital investment and specialised jobs, positioning a state as a digital economy hub; but they also strain local electricity and water resources

- **What Is "Hyperscale"?**

- **Refers to data centre facilities built at massive scale, typically for major cloud/AI providers, capable of rapidly scaling compute and storage resources**

Thank You